

FOI Deadline Tracker

Day 2 — what we shipped

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The brief

What it is

A small Flask app that logs FOI requests and calculates the statutory 20-working-day response deadline. Replaced a spreadsheet in March.

Who uses it

The DfT central FOI team — 6 caseworkers. Two more directorates are asking for accounts, which means real users and real personal data.

Why it matters now

The ICO has confirmed an autumn audit. A missed statutory deadline is a breach of the FOI Act — and the tracker had already caused one.

Before → After

Inherited prototype

- Deadline skipped weekends only — no bank holidays
- SQL injection in search + all writes
- `secret_key = 'dev', debug=True` in prod
- No audit log — no record of views or changes
- 'Backup': Gary's USB stick on Fridays
- Zero tests. Ran on Gary's desktop.

What we handed back

- 20 working days, all 4 UK nations of bank holidays
- Parameterised queries everywhere
- `SECRET_KEY` from env, debug opt-in only
- Append-only audit log — every view and every change
- Verified online-snapshot backup + restore drill
- 80 tests. Containerised, systemd, CI, healthcheck.

The bug that mattered

A request received Maundy Thursday, 2 April 2026:

Buggy deadline: 30 April 2026

Correct deadline: 5 May 2026

5 days too early — three bank holidays missed:

- Good Friday (3 Apr)
- Easter Monday (6 Apr)
- Early May bank holiday (4 May)

Every missed bank holiday = one statutory breach the ICO can flag.

Evidence it works

```
python -m pytest -q
```

```
80 passed in 5.15s
```

Backup / restore drill (Gary's machine dies)

```
$ sqlite3 data/foi.db 'SELECT COUNT(*) FROM requests;' → 13
$ python -m scripts.backup → foi-20260716-102049.db
$ rm data/foi.db # disaster
$ python -m scripts.restore → restored from newest
$ sqlite3 data/foi.db 'SELECT COUNT(*) FROM requests;' → 13
```

```
curl /api/healthz
```

```
{ "db": true, "ok": true }
```

Not done — how we'd prioritise a Day 3

1. Login + per-user accounts

Unlocks real audit actor, access control, directorate separation. Highest leverage.

2. Right-to-erasure (GDPR)

Endpoint that blanks name/address, keeps ref for stats. Direct answer to the brief.

3. Email alerts at deadline – 3 days

The operational feature that makes caseworkers trust the tool over the spreadsheet.

4. Exceptions report + annual FOI stats

One page for the Monday meeting; one export for the annual return.